

# THE INFINITIVE

## The Continuation

*Starred Verbs · Question Words · Whether · Object+Infinitive ·  
Split Infinitive · Nouns*

That-Clause

Question  
Words

Whether

Object+Inf

Split Inf

Nouns+Inf

# Starred Verbs → That-Clause Equivalents

Starred verbs (\*) can replace the to-infinitive with a that-clause without changing the meaning.

› *I promise to wait.*

› *I promise that I will wait.*

› *He pretended to be angry.*

› *He pretended that he was angry.*

› *She agreed to help.*

› *She agreed that she would help.*

› *They refused to leave.*

› *They refused that they would not leave.*

› *He claimed to know her.*

› *He claimed that he knew her.*

# learn · forget · remember: Different Meanings!

⚠ These three verbs change meaning depending on whether they are followed by to-infinitive OR that-clause.

## LEARN

+ to-inf:

*He learnt to look after himself.*  
(= He acquired the skill of looking after himself.)

+ that:

*He learnt that he would look after himself.*  
(= He discovered / found out the fact.)

## FORGET

+ to-inf:

*He forgot to leave the car keys on the table.*  
(= He didn't leave them — the action was NOT done.)

+ that:

*He forgot that his brother wanted to use the car.*  
(= He didn't remember the fact / information.)

## REMEMBER

+ to-inf:

*She remembered to go to the party.*  
(= She remembered and then went — action WAS done.)

+ that:

*She suddenly remembered that her keys were in another bag.*  
(= She recalled the fact / piece of information.)

# Infinitive with Question Words

ask · decide · explain · forget · know · show · tell · understand +  
where/how/what/who/when + to-infinitive

S + V + how / what / when / where / who + to-infinitive

how

*He discovered how to open the safe.*

when

*I didn't know when to switch the machine off.*

which

*I showed her which button to press.*

how

*She asked me how to use the washing machine.*

where

*The clerk asked where to place all the documents.*

what

*Can you explain what to do next?*

who

*I couldn't decide who to invite to the meeting.*

when

*Tell me when to start the engine.*

where

*She forgot where to put the spare key.*

what

*He understood what to say at the interview.*

# Whether + Infinitive

whether + infinitive expresses a choice or uncertainty between two alternatives.

**STRUCTURE 1: S + wonder / want to know + whether + infinitive**

*I wondered whether to phone or not.*

*He wanted to know whether to submit the documents or not.*

*She couldn't decide whether to accept the job offer or not.*

**STRUCTURE 2: S + not + decide / know / remember / think + whether + infinitive**

*You needn't decide whether to study arts or science.*

*He couldn't remember whether to run left or right.*

*I didn't know whether to continue studying or not.*

*She doesn't think whether to apply for the scholarship.*

*I couldn't decide whether to stay or leave the meeting.*

*They couldn't know whether to take the train or drive.*

# Object + Infinitive Structure

Used when one person ADVISES, COMMANDS, PERSUADES or INVITES another person to do something.

**S + V + Object + (not) to-infinitive**

advise

allow

bribe

command

compel

enable

encourage

entitle

forbid

force

implore

induce

instruct

invite

oblige

order

permit

persuade

remind

request

show how

teach

tempt

train

urge

warn

# Object + Infinitive — Examples (I)

want

*I want you to clean the duster.*

advise

*The doctor advises all children to have vaccinations.*

urge

*Lawyers will urge the parents to take further legal action.*

enable

*These glasses will enable you to see in the dark.*

encourage

*She encouraged me to try again.*

forbid

*They forbade her to leave the house.*

induce

*Nothing would induce me to do business with them.*

persuade

*They persuaded us to go with them.*

train

*They are training these dogs to sniff out drugs.*

teach

*He taught me to obey all commands without questions.*

# Object + Infinitive — Examples (II) incl. Negatives

For **NEGATIVE** instructions, place **NOT** before the to-infinitive: **S + V + Object + not + to-infinitive**

warn

*The doctor warned us **NOT** to eat the fish.*

forbid

*He forbade me **NOT** to tell this to anyone.*

implore

*Sarah implored her parents **NOT** to send her to boarding school.*

request

*Visitors are requested **NOT** to walk on the grass. (Passive)*

allow

*The loophole allowed hundreds of drink-drivers to avoid prosecution.*

bribe

*They bribed the waiter to find them a better table.*

oblige

*The law obliges companies to pay decent wages.*

tempt

*We tempted him to join the campaign.*

compel

*Mother compelled the boy to wear heavy clothes.*

remind

*Please remind your mother to call me.*

# SHOW & TELL — Special Infinitive Uses

## SHOW + object + how + infinitive

*(demonstrates how an action is performed)*

- He showed me how to change a fuse.
- He *showed me to change a fuse.* (WRONG)
- The instructor showed us how to turn off a computer.
- She showed the students how to solve the equation.

## TELL + sb + infinitive (= order / command)

*(gives a direct instruction)*

- He told me to change the fuse.
- He said, 'Change the fuse.'
- The captain told the soldiers to assemble the guns.
- She told the children to go to bed immediately.

## TELL + sb + how + infinitive (= instruct)

*(gives information or instructions on a process)*

- He told me how to replace a fuse.
- The chef told me how to cook a perfect risotto.
- She told us how to apply for the scholarship.

# Split Infinitives

A split infinitive occurs when an ADVERB is placed between 'to' and V1: to [adverb] V1

## FORMAL (unsplit)

*to master this subject completely*

*to cover the floor completely*

*to alarm people unduly*

*to finish the task promptly*

*to answer the question correctly*

## INFORMAL / COLLOQUIAL (split)

*to really master this subject*

*to completely cover the floor*

*to unduly alarm people*

*to promptly finish the task*

*to correctly answer the question*



Split infinitives are widely accepted in modern English — avoid only in highly formal/academic writing.

# Infinitive after Nouns

Certain nouns can be followed directly by a to-infinitive.

ability

ambition

anxiety

attempt

decision

demand

desire

determination

eagerness

effort

failure

offer

plan

promise

refusal

request

scheme

willingness

wish

*He couldn't realize his **ambition** to run his own business.*

***Willingness** to help people is a man's good character.*

# Noun / Pronoun + Infinitive

A noun or pronoun can be followed by an infinitive acting as a relative clause expressing purpose or obligation.

## Simple Noun + Infinitive

*I have letters to write.*

(= that I must write)

*Does he get enough to eat?*

(= that he wants to eat)

*Have you got anything to say?*

(= that you want to say)

*There is nothing to do.*

(= that can be done)

*She has many problems to solve.*

(= that she must solve)

## Noun + Infinitive + Preposition

*someone to talk to*

= someone whom I want to talk to

*cushions to sit on*

= cushions that we sit on

*a tool to open with*

= a tool we can open the box with

*a case to keep my records in*

= a case in which I will keep my records

*a glass to drink out of*

= a glass out of which I drink

*a table to write on*

= a table on which I write

# make · let · help — Causative & Permission

## MAKE (= force / cause)

**ACTIVE: S + make + sb/sth + V (bare infinitive)**

**PASSIVE: S<sub>p</sub> + be made + to-infinitive**

- A** *He made me move his car.*
- A** *Her parents made her stay home.*
- A** *The vet made the dog vomit.*
- P** *I was made to move his car.*
- P** *She was made to stay home.*
- P** *The dog was made to vomit.*

## LET (= allow / permit)

**ACTIVE: S + let + sb/sth + V (bare infinitive)**

**PASSIVE: (no passive — use 'be allowed to')**

- A** *They let him see the documents.*
- A** *I may let you stay up late.*
- A** *Since he needs money, let him earn it.*
- A** *She let the children play in the garden.*

## HELP (= assist)

**ACTIVE: S + help + sb/sth + infinitive OR bare infinitive**

**PASSIVE: (both forms accepted)**

- A** *He helped us (to) push it.*
- A** *The loan will help her (to) start her own business.*
- A** *This manual will help you (to) boost your English.*

# but / except + Bare Infinitive

After do + anything / nothing / everything/something + but / except → use BARE INFINITIVE (no 'to')

do + anything / nothing / everything + but / except + V (bare)

*He does nothing but complain.*

*My dog does everything but speak.*

*Can't you do anything but ask silly questions?*

*There is nothing to do but wait.*

*She did nothing but cry the whole evening.*

*He did everything except apologize.*

*I can do anything but give up.*

*They did nothing except sit and stare.*

Note: 'but' and 'except' are interchangeable in this structure. The bare infinitive (NOT to-infinitive) always follows.

# Quick Reference Summary

## 1 That-Clause

promise to wait  
= promise that I will wait  
(\*starred verbs only)

## 2 learn/forget/remember

+ to-inf = do/don't do action  
+ that = recall a fact

## 3 Question Words

ask/know/decide/show +  
how/what/when/where +  
to-inf

## 4 Whether

wonder whether to phone  
couldn't decide whether to  
go

## 5 Object + Inf

advise / urge / train /  
enable + obj + to-inf

## 6 Split Infinitive

to really master → informal  
to master really → formal

## 7 Nouns + Inf

ability / ambition / effort /  
promise / refusal + to-inf

## 8 make • let • help

MAKE → be made + to-inf  
(passive)  
LET / HELP → bare infinitive

## 9 but / except

do nothing BUT wait  
do everything EXCEPT  
complain

# Keep Building!

*Master the infinitive in all its forms and structures.*

- ✓ Practise starred verbs with both infinitive and that-clause
- ✓ Learn / forget / remember — always check which meaning is intended
- ✓ Use question-word infinitives to ask for instructions politely
- ✓ Whether + infinitive for expressing choices or uncertainty
- ✓ Make (passive) → be made TO do · Let/Help → bare infinitive